

Step Four: Rituals

By the time you reach this fourth step you have made an interpretation. You have done your best to understand the dream with your *mind*. Now it is time to do something *physical*. This step is very important because it helps you to integrate your dream experience into your conscious, waking life.

For some people this is a difficult stage of the dream work. When I ask, “What are you going to *do* about your dream?” they draw a blank. Yet, with a little practice, you learn to use your imagination and invent ingenious rituals that will give your dream immediacy and physical concreteness. You will be surprised at how much power this fourth step has to intensify your understanding of the dream, and even to change your habits and attitudes.

ACTING CONSCIOUSLY TO HONOR DREAMS

This step requires a *physical act* that will affirm the message of the dream. It could be a practical act: As a result of your dream, you may feel that you need to start paying your bills on time or straighten out a relationship that has become confused. Or it may be a symbolic act—a ritual that brings home the meaning of the dream in a powerful way.

Many examples come to mind. People sometimes dream that they need to be more aware of their feeling side, their feeling values. For such a dream you could make a ritual of spending one evening doing something that has deep value, that feels important and uplifting, but for which you never have time. Or do some small, subtle thing to show your affection to someone you care about. Small things work best: for example, dropping by for a short visit or sending a card. Any physical ritual will serve if it affirms the message of your dream.

If your dream tells you that you spend too much time on work, that you need more physical relaxation, you could make a ritual of taking yourself to the beach or some rural place, going for a long walk, focusing your eyes on the colors of earth and sky, reconnecting to the physical world. Even small acts like these have the power to make your dream concrete and to begin its integration into your conscious life.

One of the best rituals that I remember was done by a young college

student who was analyzing with me. He dreamed that he was out in a shopping center on Saturday night. He went from place to place, and everything went badly for him. He found “junk food” that made him sick, superficial acquaintanceships, things to buy that left him unsatisfied.

He worked hard on the first three steps of his dream work. His interpretation was that the dream referred to his “Saturday night syndrome.” This consisted of “going out with the guys,” drinking a lot, eating unhealthy food, getting into adventures and acquaintanceships that felt empty afterwards. He decided, in light of his dream, that this kind of socializing or recreation was not healthy for him. It represented a set of values and a way of life that didn’t belong to him.

I asked him: “What did you do about your dream? What was your fourth step?”

He decided that the essence of the dream was captured in the phrase, “junk food.” In his dream he experienced the junk food of human relationship and collectivity. Like junk food, it gave him no nourishment in his inner life, his feeling life, or even in human relatedness. So he created this ritual for his dream:

He went to a hamburger stand and bought the biggest deluxe cheeseburger and an order of french fries. He got a shovel and took the junk food to his backyard. He dug a hole and buried the cheeseburger and fries with high, solemn ceremony. He did this as a symbolic act of renunciation. He ritually affirmed his intention to give up the superficial and destructive involvements that the dream had called to his attention.

This dream and this ritual had a profound effect on him. They initiated a great evolution in his consciousness, strength, and maturity. The ritual cured him of seeking nourishment where it could not be found, of giving his life over to people and activities that could not feed him on any deep level.

This is an instructive example of what our society does to our young people in general. We have lost the traditional forms of collectivity—the family, the clan, the school, the church—that would nourish them psychologically and spiritually. Most of the social forms and activities available to them do not contribute to their physical health or to their inner well-being. This general situation is well symbolized by the dream image of young people milling around a shopping center, aimlessly searching for something to do, someplace to go, a meaning or a connectedness that can’t be found there. There is nothing inherently wrong with shopping centers. It is

the shopping center *mentality*, shown in this young man's dream, that is the crux of the problem.

People are usually surprised to learn that the most powerful rituals are the small ones, the subtle ones. It is not necessary to do big things or expensive things. In fact, it is counterproductive to put out huge amounts of time or energy on your dream ritual. Don't set out to clean the entire house or try to whip your entire business into shape in one day because you had a dream that told you to get better organized. It is best that you not try to involve all your friends. You don't need to organize a jogging club and elect officers just because your dream told you to get more exercise.

Keep your physical rituals small and subtle, and they will be more powerful. The ritual is a physical representation of the inner attitude change that the dream called for, and it is this level of change that is requested by the dream.

It is also not a good idea to try to make a ritual out of talking about your dream or trying to explain yourself to people. Talking tends to put the whole experience back on an abstract level. It gets contaminated with your desire to present yourself in the best light. Instead of a vivid, private experience, you wind up with an amorphous, collective chat. The best rituals are physical, solitary, and silent: These are the ones that register most deeply with the unconscious.

USING THE BODY

Doing a physical act has a magical effect on dream work. It takes your understanding of the dream off the purely abstract level and gives it an immediate, concrete reality. It is a way of putting your dream into the here-and-now of your physical life.

Ritual and ceremony in general are ways of using small, symbolic acts to set up a connection between the conscious mind and the unconscious. Rituals provide us a way of taking principles from the unconscious and impressing them vividly on the conscious mind. But rituals also have an effect on the unconscious. A highly conscious ritual sends a powerful message back to the unconscious, causing changes to take place at the deep levels where our attitudes and values originate.

Once you have understood the meaning of your dream with your conscious mind, it is necessary to transplant your awareness and consciousness back into the deeper levels of the unconscious. We can think

of this as taking a seed from a plant that has sprouted and replanting it back into the soil from which it grew. In the same way, when we replant our consciousness back into the unconscious, it produces new energy and new life below in the primal matter. The cycle of generation continues, and new forms push their way up to the level of consciousness.

Many years ago, when I was studying at the Jung Institute in Zurich, the famous Toni Wolffe (a colleague of Jung) was still working with patients there as an analyst. On this particular subject, doing something concrete about your dream, she was known as a holy terror. She met her patients at the door, and before they could even get into a chair, she would demand: “And what did you *do* about that dream from last week?”

Patients who had done something specific, something concrete and physical, were safe from the wrath to come. But if they hemmed and hawed, said they had thought about it a little, had talked with someone about it, or some such vague thing, she would turn them around and steer them back through the door. As the door was slamming behind them, she would say: “Come back when you mean business.” That was the way it was with her, and everyone knew it: You either worked or you fled.

Toni Wolffe’s idea was that dreams exist in modern people too much as airy thoughts, too much as abstractions in the head. One has to notify the rest of one’s body that one has dreamed. She said: “People can analyze for twenty years, and nothing below the neck is aware that anything is going on! You have to do something about it. Do something with your muscles!”

Our tendency in the West is to make everything abstract, to use wordy discussion as a substitute for direct feeling experience. We have a tremendous need to get our bodies and our feelings involved. We have to transform our theoretical ideas into “gut-level” experience. Ideas and images from your dream should enter into your emotions, your muscle fibers, the cells of your body. It takes a physical act. When it registers physically, it also registers at the deepest levels of the psyche.

REDISCOVERING THE POWER OF RITUAL

Just as we have to overcome cultural prejudices in order to approach the unconscious, we also have to drop some of our ingrained prejudices in order to respect ritual as a necessary and helpful part of human life. Some of us automatically accept the idea that rituals are no more than remnants of a superstitious past or outdated religious beliefs. The words *ritual* and

ceremony are often used disparagingly to mean “empty and meaningless formality.”

In recent years, however, many people have become interested in shamanism and in the rituals of native American and other tribal cultures. We have begun to rediscover ritual as a natural human tool for connecting to our inner selves, focusing and refining our religious insights, and constellating psychological energy. We are beginning to learn that we have impoverished ourselves by giving up what our tribal ancestors had as part of their daily spiritual lives.

Jung anticipated this new awareness decades ago when he demonstrated that ritual and ceremony are important avenues to the unconscious: Ritual is a means of approaching the inner world that the human race evolved early in its history. The use of ritual goes back to the earliest dawn of time among our prehistoric ancestors. Ritual is one of the faculties we have, like dreaming, that enable us to set up a flow of communication between the conscious mind and the unconscious. Our instinctual hunger for meaningful ritual stays with us today, even though we have lost our sense of its psychological and spiritual role in our lives.

One of the meanings of the word *ceremony*, in its original Latin form, was “awe.” A ceremony was a way of behaving when one felt a sense of awe or stood in awe. All the set formality around religious ceremony is an indication of the reverence and awe that people felt at one time regarding the object of the ceremony. It is natural for human beings to show reverence through formality, to use highly ritualized symbolic acts as a way to carefully approach the inner world.

How does this apply to dreams? When you have begun to experience your dreams, you sense that there is an enormous power and intelligence behind them. You feel that your dreams are revealing layers of your soul that you never knew, touching on themes that are so important that your whole sense of life and its meaning begins to be rearranged.

It is then that we need to know about ritual and its role in human life. Our religious lives are reawakened, we find ourselves facing the divine world, and we need ritual just as desperately as did the ancients before us. We need to make rituals in order to touch those dream energies and evolve them while at the same time maintaining our equilibrium in daily life. We need to express our awe and elation and gratitude—and sometimes, our terror. For all this,

ritual is the channel that our instincts provide for us. In this, we are not different from our primordial ancestors.

All my experience as a psychologist leads me to the conclusion that a sense of *reverence* is necessary for psychological health. If a person has no sense of reverence, no feeling that there is anyone or anything that inspires awe, it generally indicates an ego inflation that cuts the conscious personality off completely from the nourishing springs of the unconscious. It is ironic, then, that so much of our modern culture is aimed at eradicating all reverence, all respect for the high truths and qualities that inspire a feeling of awe and worship in the human soul.

Ritual, in its true form, is one of the most meaningful channels for our awe and sense of worship. This is why ritual came spontaneously into being among humans in all parts of the earth. This is why modern people who are deprived of meaningful ritual feel a chronic sense of emptiness. They are denied contact with the great archetypes that nourish our soul-life.

If we look at ritual from a psychological standpoint, we may say that correct ritual is *symbolic behavior, consciously performed*. Different persons will have different language to express what is symbolized by the ritual acts. But the highest form of ritual has this characteristic: Those who participate sense that they are doing an act that has symbolic meaning, and they consciously seek to transform that act into an *active, dynamic symbol*. Their every movement becomes a symbol-in-motion that carries the power of the inner world into visible and physical form.

Whether we are aware of it or not, much of our behavior is symbolic. But what transforms physical acts into high ritual is the expression of symbolism within a *conscious* act. At its best, ritual is a series of physical acts that expresses in condensed form one's relationship to the inner world of the unconscious.

The role of ritual in the growth of consciousness is related to its power to make symbolic experience into something physical and concrete. Although we can understand the meaning of symbols with our minds, our understanding is made immeasurably deeper and more concrete when we *feel* the symbols with our bodies and our feelings. When we only think about symbols, or talk about them, we are able to detach ourselves too readily from the feeling quality that surrounds them. But if we *do* something to express the

symbol—something that involves our bodies and our emotions—the symbol becomes a living reality for us. It etches itself indelibly on our consciousness.

Ritual is the tool that makes it possible to bring forth the essence of a dream situation, the essence of the principle the dream teaches, the essence of the archetypal energy in the dream; ritual reduces the voltage enough that we can translate them into immediate, concrete acts.

Without thinking about it in psychological terms, ancient and primitive cultures have always understood instinctively that ritual had a true function in their psychic lives. They understood ritual as a set of formal acts that brought them into immediate contact with the gods. Ritual served many purposes: It allowed them to show respect and reverence to the great Powers. It permitted them to touch the Power—the Power did not overwhelm them or possess them because the exchange was contained within the safe limits of ritual.

Like the burning bush that protected Moses' eyes from the sight of Jehovah, the animal forms of Zeus that shielded Semele from his horrible power (until she was so foolish as to demand to see him in his full godhead and was incinerated), the ritual protects the fragile ego consciousness of individual and tribe from the raw power of the unconscious. When ancient and primitive cultures spoke of “going to the gods” in their rituals, it meant in their archaic language that they approached the great and terrible archetypes of the collective unconscious.

In our time it is still the fashion to think of all this as naive and superstitious. But other cultures had a great advantage over us: They at least recognized the *existence* of the psychic realm, however they spoke of it, and learned to approach it through ritual and dream. By contrast, we modern people have mostly given up the language of religion. But few of us have found any other language for approaching the realm of the soul, and the terrible by-product of this is that we have forgotten its existence. In this respect we are worse off than our so-called primitive ancestors.

When we are learning to pay attention to our dreams and our inner world is the perfect time for us to rediscover the marvelous human faculty for ritual. There are no set rituals established for us, nothing that is prescribed by a formula or a tradition. Instead, each of us must go into our own imaginations and literally “dream” the ritual that will serve to honor a particular dream.

Each ritual must be custom-made out of the raw material of your own inner self. It flows out of the same inner place that produced your dream,

your associations, and your interpretation. All inner work becomes much less threatening when we begin to see that every expression of the unconscious—whether dream, imagination, vision, or ritual—proceeds from the same reservoir deep within. And everything, therefore, works together.

THE CEREMONY OF THE FLOWERS

To illustrate ways that different people have custom-designed simple rituals to honor their dreams, we will look at a few more examples.

The first takes us back to a dream that we looked at earlier: the Dream of the Monastery. You may recall that I said earlier we would be returning to this dream to see what had happened with the dream and the dreamer when she approached the fourth step of dream work.

The dreamer's experience illustrates a fact that is well known to people who work regularly with their dreams: If we do our work inwardly and do small rituals to express our inner situation, it often generates a great charge of constructive energy in the external world around us and shapes our external circumstances in ways that we would never have anticipated. This is part of the evidence we have for the existence of the collective unconscious: We find that the unconscious connects us to other people and to our entire environment; therefore, when we focus a great deal of energy within the inner world, a parallel energy often arises in the people or situations around us. In this way we can do healing through our inner work that we never could have done through external means.

Here again is the Dream of the Monastery.

In the Monastery

I am in a monastic cloister, in a room or cell attached to the chapel. I am separated from the people and the rest of the chapel by a grille. Mass begins. I participate alone in my cell. I sit with crossed legs, *zazen* style, but holding my rosary. I hear the murmurs of the responses through the grille. The voices are tranquil. I close my eyes and I too receive communion, although no one and nothing physical enters my cell. The mass finishes. I become aware of flowers blooming at the side of my chamber. I feel a deep serenity.

After this woman worked on her dream, she saw the implications for her religious life and practice. But she couldn't think of anything *physical* to do about it. It seemed to be a matter of inner vision, of understanding inwardly. No outer act was implied: In fact, if she ran out and began searching for a religious group to join it would violate the spirit of the dream, which was to

be quiet in her own awareness of the spirit.

Finally the young woman thought of a simple symbolic act she could do that would express her feelings about the dream and its meaning to her: In the dream, when she had received communion she saw that flowers had burst spontaneously into bloom at the side of her cell during the mass. She went and gathered flowers like those in her dream. She drove to the ocean with the flowers and made a solemn ceremony of going to the edge of the sea and casting the flowers into the waves.

She did this as a physical, yet symbolic, act of giving the gift she had received back to Mother Earth, back to the feminine sea of the unconscious. She felt at the time that this was too little, that she should think of something grander to do in honor of such a wonderful dream. But it was all she could think of, so she did it. She felt immensely grateful for the dream, and this was an act of gratitude toward God and toward the inner feminine.

Leaving the ocean, she drove quietly back to her house and found that a friend had come to visit while she was at the beach—a friend whom she did not see very often. Together they took a short drive around the neighborhood. Then several things occurred in rapid succession that seemed like coincidences, yet could not be.

First, as they drove, she discovered that there was a monastery in her neighborhood, just a few blocks from her home. She was startled, for inwardly she had been in a monastery all night and all morning. Her friend was one of the few laypeople who had permission to enter the cloister, and she even had a key for the gate! Her friend suggested that they stop and visit the chapel and greet the nuns.

When our dreamer walked into the monastery chapel, she felt as though she had walked back into her dream. The chapel, which she had never seen before, was identical to the chapel in her dream. Every detail was the same. She settled down by herself in the chapel to meditate in *zazen* posture, and all the meanings, feelings, and intense serenity of the dream experience flowed through her again.

In the days that followed she too was granted permission to visit the monastery regularly to meditate, spend quiet time, and nourish the part of her that is a monastic. The Dream of the Monastery became an external, physical reality as well as an inner reality in the Land of Dreaming. The inner flow and the outer flow became parallel energy systems moving in tandem.

The paradox in all this is that, at the point where she was ready to give up

all external forms of “belonging” or of institutional religion, this woman suddenly found herself in a physical monastery, a physical chapel, a physical group of nuns with whom she can spend a few hours of her week in a sense of religious community. And none of this contradicts the inner monastery, the inner life of the spirit shown in her dream that is beyond external and collective religious forms.

As you can see, the ritual that the dreamer did for her great dream did not seem very dramatic to her. But her “ceremony of the flowers” was exactly appropriate to the simple and powerful symbols in the dream. It generated a connection between the inner world of the dream and the outer physical world, facilitated the synchronous events later in the day, and tied the two sides of her reality together.

If we learn to live this way, we find that all our dreams manifest both inwardly and outwardly. It is only our unawareness that prevents us from seeing the subtle connections. Our rituals and ceremonies can help us to see where the inner world and the physical world meet, and where they reflect each other as they move in parallel fields of energy.

WHEN YOU CAN'T THINK OF ANYTHING TO DO

You can always do a simple physical act, even if you can't think of something that relates directly to your dream. Go out and walk around the block in honor of your dream, if that is all you can think of. Light a candle. Do *something*. If you consciously do some act—any act—in honor of your dream, it will register with your unconscious.

I remember a marvelous man, a monk, who came to do analysis with me. He had never come closer to the incarnate world than Thomas Aquinas. He was an intellectual, and everything for him was spiritual, theoretical, and abstract. In response to his dreams he did the most airy flights in fantasy and theology. But his dreams never seemed to register with him in his emotional life, his practical life, his relationship to people or to the world around him.

Everything was fine until we came to the fourth stage of dream work. Then he would get angry with me. He didn't see why he should do anything about the dream. He thought it enough to understand with his mind, to grasp the theory.

One day we worked on a dream, and he got angry with me as usual and said, “So, what do you expect me to do about *this* one?” An irrational response jumped out of some place in my unconscious: “You could go out and look at the bark of ten trees in honor of the dream.”

He looked at me, startled, stood up, muttered something, and backed out of the room. I felt a little sheepish. There wasn't anything about trees or bark in the dream. I was just as startled at what had come out of my mouth as he was.

About three hours later the monk came pounding on my door in high excitement. He said: "Robert! You don't know how interesting the bark on trees is! Some of it is brown; some is gray; some is smooth; some has great wrinkles in it. And little creatures live in it. It is a different color on the north side than on the south side, and moss grows on it, and...and you wouldn't believe how beautiful and interesting the bark on trees is!"

In that three hours, this man awakened for the first time to his physical being and to the physical world. He saw the spirit *in* the physical world, rather than dissociated from it. It was as though we had fashioned a Zen Buddhist *koan*: "What is the bark on ten trees?"

Koans are cryptic statements or vignettes that Zen *roshis* (masters) traditionally give to monks, ordering them to find the "answer" to the *koan*. But the *koan* is so constructed that no answer can be found within ordinary ego-logic. The monks must push themselves out of traditional categories and over the brink into irrational, intuitive wisdom. One famous example of a *koan* is this: Show me the sound of one hand clapping.

As with all *koans*, there can be no ordinary answer to the question, What is the bark on ten trees? But my friend discovered, as his answer, that you find the entire universe in the bark of ten trees!

USING COMMON SENSE

Your imagination will usually produce a good physical ritual for your dream. You should go to your imagination for help on this: As we have learned, imagination and dreams come from the same source, and they are consonant. But not everything your imagination produces should be acted out externally. You still have to use your head!

The Hindu saint Sri Aurobindo once said, "Why is it that when people begin to relinquish the world, the first thing they relinquish is common sense?" You may feel as you confront the new and magical world of dreams that you are giving up your old, narrow world. But don't give up on common sense. Don't give up on courtesy or respect toward the people around you. This fourth step of dream work, this physical ritual, is a very powerful tool that can affect your life profoundly if it is used constructively. But if you use it in a silly or irresponsible way, it can cause you and other people a lot of

grief. Think twice before you do things that are too dramatic or confrontational, that will involve other people and their feelings.

You should avoid doing things in response to your dreams that will get you unnecessarily into trouble. You should not get into destructive confrontations with other people. Don't use your dream as a license to act out.

Sometimes a dream will remind us of a conflict with another person. Or it may galvanize some longing in us to "break free from it all," to give up the restraints of society, responsibility, or commitment. In those situations you should be careful not to overreact, not to start rearranging your world or your relationships without giving it some long and careful thought. You can do a lot of damage if you go off "half-cocked."

Once I had a patient who was in graduate school. He was irritated with his roommate, a close friend, because his roommate was irresponsible. One night my patient dreamed that he gave his roommate an angry lecture and it ended in a fistfight.

When he awakened, his first impulse was to go and tell off his roommate, tell him what an ass he was, and have it out with him. But instead he did his dream work. He asked, "Who is the one *inside me* who is represented by my roommate's image?" He began to realize that he was really most upset with his *own* irresponsibility, which kept him from studying for his classes. He had chosen his friend's image to represent his own tendency to be lazy and disorganized.

When he came to the fourth step of dream work, he asked himself what physical ritual he could do to make his dream concrete. The temptation to go fight with his friend was still very strong, but he resisted it.

Instead, he sat down and wrote a long letter addressed to the part of himself that needed to grow up, make some decisions, and be an adult. He wrote several pages. He explained everything he had learned about taking responsibility, making choices and sacrifices, sticking to a schedule—everything that his *inner* "roommate" needed to know.

He put the letter in an envelope, addressed the envelope to himself, then went to the post office and made a formal ceremony of posting it. The next day the letter arrived in the mail. When he opened this envelope addressed to himself, he was shaken. It was as though the voice of the unconscious, coming from far away, was speaking to him through the letter. For weeks after that, he wrote a letter to himself every few days and mailed it to himself.

With each letter that he received, the message and the implications of his dream burned themselves more deeply into his consciousness. It permanently altered his view of his life.

This example illustrates our principle: The fourth step of dream work does not consist in dramatically confronting people you are angry with, breaking up relationships, or doing destructive things. It does not consist of trying to “straighten things out” with a lot of talk. That leads nowhere. It should be a physical ritual that affirms your own personal responsibility for your dream and for the issue it portrays.

If you do have unfinished business with some external person, you will be able to approach it in a constructive and noncombative way after you have done your dream work, done your private ritual, taken responsibility for your share of the confusion.

Keep your rituals subtle and low-key, positive and affirmative, and you will get the best from them.

Ritual is one of our most powerful tools for making a synthesis between the polarities of human reality. It is an art that ties our two halves together. The archetypal, spiritual *yang* needs to be tied to the here-and-now earthiness of our *yin* nature. The masculine spirit, that gets so lost in abstraction and theory, needs to be anchored to the feminine earth, needs to experience directly the feminine soul. The path to the feminine side of reality is through concreteness, matter as *mater* (mother), earth-connectedness. All of this constellates most directly through the physical act.

The world you see in your dream is the inner world that exists outside time and space. Some of its energy and its message must be *incarnated* into this human world of the here-and-now. It must find its way into your daily life, for its truth is lost unless you live it.

DREAM WORK ILLUSTRATION: THE FOUR HOODLUMS

To illustrate our four-step system in a practical way, I am going to work through a sample dream, and you are invited to join me. This is a fairly short dream that I had many years ago. But dreams that seem small and simple can have earth-shaking implications for the dreamer, as this one did for me. This dream also illustrates how archetypal references can be used in combination with purely personal associations to produce a sense of the dream’s message.

Here is my dream.

The Dream of the Four Hoodlums

I am in my hometown, Portland, Oregon. I am walking on Williams

Avenue, the street I used to walk down to get to grammar school. This is my old neighborhood, just as it was in the days of my childhood. I walk past the Japanese greengrocer's on the corner, and the store is still there. It seems that I am visiting the old neighborhood. I feel that I am my present age, but I've been transported back to that place as it once was.

I walk past a vacant lot. I feel that there is something lurking there. I have a sudden intuition that I will be robbed. I stop and take my wallet out of my hip pocket and remove the cash. I see that I have forty dollars. I slip the cash into my left shirt pocket, over my chest, and put the wallet back into my hip pocket.

Four young hoodlums jump out of the shrubbery and surround me. I know that this is the robbery I intuited. I see it is useless to run: There are four of them; they are younger and stronger than I. They are "street people" and can easily overpower me.

They search me carefully, starting at my shoes and working upward. When they reach my hip pockets, they find my wallet but no money, so they keep searching. When they get to my shirt pocket on the left side, they find the forty dollars. But, by that time, they have spent so much time with me and there has been so much physical touching that they "know me." In a sense we have become acquainted, become friends.

They stay, talking with me in a friendly way, but they don't take my money, because now we are friends, and you don't take your friends' money. I feel absurdly happy to have these hoodlums as friends and like them very much.

STEP ONE: MAKING THE ASSOCIATIONS

As we go through the dream, I am going to use two formats to illustrate two ways that you can lay out your associations on paper. The first format is very concise and abbreviated. As you see below, I put the symbol in the left margin, and then write down, in the most abbreviated form, whatever associations come out of my mind in response to the symbol.

The second format is more a conversational way of talking to yourself on paper about your associations. I will also use the second format as an informal commentary for the reader, explaining how I came up with some of my associations. You may use either of these formats, or use the "wheel and spokes" method of diagraming that we learned earlier.

As you read through this material, you will notice that I usually have a lot of associations with every image, and only a few of those associations really

turn out to “click” or fit into the final interpretation. In fact, you might find yourself getting impatient with all this meandering, page after page, through associations that don’t turn out to be applicable in the end.

I have deliberately left in all these associations so that you can see what a person actually has to go through in order to try out all the different associations, find the ones that “click,” fit them to inner parts of the self, and finally weld everything together into an interpretation. It took me a couple of weeks of returning to this dream and coming up with associations before it all started to fall into place. But it was worth it: The dream altered my conception of who I am and changed the course of my life.

My Associations to the Dream Symbols

Williams Avenue and the old neighborhood

Time of childhood before waking up to conflict: “Garden of Eden.”
Streets: First place child aware of people congregating, collectivity.
Beginning of collective existence. Nostalgia.

Williams Avenue represents to me that time of life when I was a child, before I “woke up” and became aware of the divisions and conflicts inherent in life. Childhood in that neighborhood, with its old wooden houses, was a simple, happy time. Williams Avenue is, for me, *the* street: the archetypal street that formed my whole feeling of streets as places where people live and congregate, where there are businesses, little hubs of civilization and human collective existence. I was in a “Garden of Eden” in that neighborhood. It was before I woke up to ethical conflicts, right and wrong, before I learned there was betrayal and hatred in the world. It is my preconscious Garden of Eden.

The Japanese greengrocer

People of another culture. Culture with ritual, ceremony, grace, delicacy. Lady in kimono. Courtesy. Basket of lilacs, rice cakes. Zen Buddhism. India. Feeling and relatedness. Relationship outside of projection, casualness, sentimentality.

The first thing that comes to mind is that this was my first experience of meeting people of another culture, and they fascinated me. I became aware, for the first time, of the differences in people, aware of a way of doing things that was ritualized, graceful, delicate. I remember that a relative arrived from Japan, dressed in a kimono. There was bowing and exchanging of courtesies while I looked on, struck with the beauty of the formalities, the courtesy and respect that old-fashioned Japanese people knew how to show, something I’d never seen in middle-class Portland among my own Anglo tribe.

The Japanese family brought out a little bit of the sense of courtesy and formality in my own family: Each year my grandmother sent a basket of lilacs to them, and a day later a package of delicate rice cakes was always delivered to our house as a return gift.

The world that the Japanese greengrocer opened up in me is a vision that I have been trying instinctively to augment ever since. It was the beginning of the impulse that led me to travel to Japan and India. I associate it with my spontaneous interest in Zen Buddhism, Eastern philosophy, Hindu culture. The Japanese family constellated a sense in me of something high, noble, and beautiful that was outside my own cultural experience.

Years later I understood that traditional Eastern people also represented to me a capacity for warmth and relatedness that is not the same as “getting personal” in the shallow, casual, artificial, back-slapping way that so many Americans use as a substitute for genuine feeling and relatedness. And Japanese culture, especially the Zen culture, represents, at its best, a true respect for the inner world, for religious experience, and for beauty. All these associations come to mind from this one symbol.

The vacant lot

Undeveloped = primitive, wild place in middle of city. Bounded by streets = limits, boundaries, form, structure. But no form in vacant lot. Uncivilized. Outside reach of law. Piece of wilderness. Have to clear weeds annually, fire hazard. Hiding place for outlaws. Retreat. Religious retreat? Shadowy place: Place of shadow? Unconscious place in the middle of conscious areas?

To me, a vacant lot is a piece of untouched, primitive land in the middle of the city. Everything around it is civilized, developed, turned to human use, but the lot is still like a piece of wilderness. Although the vacant lot is bounded and defined by streets (which I think represent “civilization” to me), it is not “civilized.” It feels like a place that is “outside the law,” like the Sherwood Forest of Robin Hood, where the hoodlums, literally “out-laws,” could lurk. I also associate it with unconsciousness and with the shadow: a place inside me that is circumscribed by consciousness but is in the shadow and outside my conscious control.

Wallet

Place where you keep money, so place for keeping resources. Credit cards, ID, therefore wallet = a kind of *passport* for getting by with people. Wallet usually goes at hip pocket, keeps money at “hip” level. Wallet =

useful, but can also be for show; pretentious, an artificial form of security.

The money

Forty dollars = four. Four = wholeness, completeness, totality, the completion of a cycle or synthesis. Money is a resource. Energy? Power? Psychological strength or power. Life force. Something you invest. Keep it at the “hip” level or at the chest level. Where is it invested? Where is it put to work?

This is where archetypal amplification begins to help. I know that numbers are very important in dreams, and I know that the number four is a traditional symbol of completeness, unity, wholeness, totality. This is so in most religions, in alchemy, in ancient philosophical systems. The Greeks believed in four elements (earth, air, fire, and water). The Christian mandala has twelve disciples grouped in four sections around Christ. The American Indians structured their religions around four directions and four winds. It represents a bringing together of the main elements of the individual into a whole consciousness.

Money seems to be associated with *resources*: perhaps physical or psychological energy or, at a deeper level, life force. Money is something one *invests*. So where am I investing my life force, my attention, my main energy? Resources are also personal talents, strengths, intelligence. You can use money to get something done: thus, a capacity for practical things, getting something accomplished. Money is something we *earn* by our efforts. It represents the accumulated value of our work, discipline, expertise.

The hip pocket

One of the *chakras* [centers of consciousness] is close to hips, the visceral, emotional side of the personality, center that controls visceral energies. To be “hip”—opium user. Origin of “hippie” = originally, into drug scene. Also hip = to be “into the scene,” “hip” to what is going on, “hip to the jive.”

I learned that the phrase *to be hip* came from the old opium subculture, where to be “on your hip” meant to lie in an opium trance. When psychedelic drugs and marijuana became popular among the Beat generation, people who were into such things were “hip.” From this came the slang “hippie.” What are my associations? Most of “hippie” life to me represents a pretense of going into a life of “love” and “spirituality” while actually being irresponsible and dependent. It is a way of staying in the negative side of the mother complex.

Another association: “shooting from the hip.”

In kundalini yoga there is a *chakra* located in the region of the hips, a center of consciousness. I think it controls the *visceral* energies, which in yogic symbolism means the raw emotions and raw, instinctual animal energies. After one has developed that center of consciousness, the consciousness has to be moved up to the higher *chakras* in the body, so moving my money away from the hip up to the chest level could mean moving the focus of my life away from the visceral or “hip” level.

The other association that clicks for me is the idea of being “hip” in the sense of “with it” or “into the scene.” I can think of examples of my investing my energy in trying to be “in” with a group of people, or connected, so that I would feel “part of the scene.”

Left shirt pocket over chest

Over heart. Heart level. Heart values = feeling values. Feeling function. *Anahata chakra* in kundalini. Invest energy at heart level. Feeling relationships to people.

This dream was like a mystery story that slowly unfolded for me. At first I could not make any associations to the left shirt pocket. I sensed that the movement of the forty dollars up to that pocket was somehow the crucial point in the dream, the one that produced all the rest of the events. But I could not for the life of me find an association that really “clicked” for me.

I don’t know how long it was—days, perhaps weeks—that I tried all sorts of crazy associations. Then it occurred to me that the pocket was over the heart, or at the level of the heart. If the pants pocket could be called the “hip” pocket, this shirt pocket could as well be called the “heart” pocket. That opened up a flood of associations. Heart values are *feeling* values. The heart level is the feeling level.

In Jung’s model, the feeling function is not connected with emotions, as some people assume. Feelings and emotions are distinct energy systems in the psyche. When people *feel*, they are actually assigning value. If you feel love toward another person, you are assigning the highest value to that person, affirming that person’s worth, value. When you *feel* that something is beautiful, you are again assigning a value or recognizing a value in that thing.

Therefore the feeling function could better be called the *valuing* function. It is the function in the psyche that has the job of recognizing values in people, things, and ideas and distinguishing what has high value from what has low value. It is your feeling function that tells you whether certain people

are good for you, “nourishing” for you, in a feeling sense, or poisonous for you. If your feeling function is working consciously, it tells you what is right for you and what would be destructive for you.

Once I saw that the shirt pocket corresponded to the *heart* level, further associations with kundalini yoga were opened up. The *anahata chakra* also is located at the level of the heart. This center of consciousness is reputed to generate and control the refined feelings: the powers of love, refined discrimination in feeling matters, appreciation of beauty, spiritual feeling, unselfish love, and relatedness toward other people. This *chakra* generates the feelings about what is good, true, noble, or beautiful. Kundalini makes the same distinction between feelings and emotions, apparently, for the raw, primitive emotions, that which makes one an “emotional” or volatile person, are associated with a lower *chakra*, while only the more refined and “rational” feelings proceed from the *anahata chakra*.

The hoodlums

Outlaws. People outside the “law” = something outside the established “order” of the conscious mind or my ego world. Outside what society has decreed. Shadow. Saboteurs, because they steal money, therefore steal my energy, power, resources. *Four* hoodlums = affinity with the fourness of the forty dollars. *Four* = completeness, unity, wholeness. Wholeness comes through the “hoodlum” side of my psyche? They steal my energy unless I put it at the heart level? *Gang* = “gang up on me.”

As you can see, my mind is already trying to skip to the second step of the dream work: I am spontaneously thinking about what part of my interior self these hoodlums are. I associate them with the *shadow*, because they seem to live within the ego’s general “field of consciousness,” that is, the civilized town, but they live in a shadowy, unconscious vacant lot, outside my consciousness or control. They are unconscious, apparently repressed, parts of my masculine side that are trying to be assimilated into the conscious ego or make a synthesis with it.

Since they are “outlaws,” this means to me that they are outside the control of my ego’s established world, outside my established attitudes or my self-image, my concept of myself.

There are *four*. This tells me that, paradoxically, although they are hoodlums and muggers, they represent *wholeness* for me. That means I have to bring them into my conscious life in order to complete the self and be a total individual.

I associate the *robbery* with a basic psychological principle: If you repress a part of yourself and keep it out of your conscious life, it turns into a robber and starts “stealing” your time and energy by creating a neurosis. This is its way of trying to force its way into your life. It sabotages you and prevents you from functioning as you want to. The “robbery” can take the form of physical symptoms, illness, neurosis, anxiety, or even “bad luck” that seems to “gang up on you” just as the four hoodlums do in this dream.

I associate the *overpowering* of my ego in the dream with the fact that the archetypes of the unconscious generally have more power than the ego. If my ego refuses to make a synthesis with the unconscious contents, the unconscious has the power to bring my ego-life to a standstill. I am brought to a halt in the dream, and if the situation were not mended in a positive way, later I would experience that “halt” in my practical life.

Search for the money

Physical contact in dreams means communication between parts of psyche. Communication between polarities: conscious-unconscious, ego-“hoodlums,” ego-shadow. Synthesis in psyche starts as conflict, ends in friendship. Search for resources. Finding money not as important as finding where I put it.

Friends, becoming friends

Ending conflict, joining forces, joining pairs of opposites: respectable ego with primitive hoodlums. Synthesis with other part of self. Synthesis with shadow. Go over to shadow’s point of view. Communication begins in conflict, stealing. Ends in synthesis or partnership. Learn from hoodlum. Make room for lawlessness in life. Friendship possible if money invested at right level.

All the interactions we see between the persons in our dreams are forms of communication among the various parts of our total self. There may be fighting, wars, love, hate, friendship, enmity—all this is a kind of rubbing together of the polarities, a “getting acquainted” among the different energy systems that coexist within us.

So this searching for the money, in a curious way, is the one form of communication my ego has with the “hoodlum,” shadow, part of myself. Most communication in the psyche begins in conflict. The unconscious parts of our personalities have to fight for “equal time,” for some recognition, against the dominant attitudes and power systems of the conscious mind. But fighting, robbing, some kind of confrontation, is better than no contact at all.

If, from the conflict, the ego can learn to open itself to the viewpoints and values of the shadow side, then the conflict slowly evolves into friendship and synthesis.

STEP TWO: APPLYING THE DREAM IMAGES TO SPECIFIC PARTS OF MYSELF AND DYNAMICS IN MY INNER LIFE

Williams Avenue

I am trying now to find the part of myself, and the actual dynamics going on inside myself, that Williams Avenue represents.

One association that clicked was the Garden of Eden: that is, it is the original, unsplit, childhood state in which one feels no division of the world. One feels completely unified with parents, family, the world around. There are no discordant issues to deal with, no conflicts.

Why would this come up in this dream? What goes on inside me that this fits into? When something of childhood comes up, that may be a sign that the dream is talking about the overall picture of one's life, the progression or developmental stages that have gone on since childhood up to the present. So, I could look for a passage from one developmental stage to another.

The clue, here, is the Japanese greengrocer. How do I contrast the quality of the Japanese family with the quality of Williams Avenue in general? If I look at this as stages and influences, it falls into place: Williams Avenue is my basic orientation to the world, as a child, in my white, middle-class, extroverted, sensation-oriented attitude.

The foreign element in my own personality that was going to come into conflict inevitably with my childhood Anglo world, is represented by the Japanese family on the corner: it is the introverted, feeling side of me, the heart quality in me, a different set of values than my Anglo culture had.

Dreams are said to have four stages of development, all of which must be present to make a complete dream:

1. *Dramatis personae* (persons and places)
2. Statement of the problem
3. Response to the problem within the dream (development)
4. *Lysis* (i.e., outcome, or resolution)

The original setting is Williams Avenue, which is my set, tight, extroverted, practical Anglo world. The problem is stated when I see the

Japanese greengrocer's. The problem is an encounter, starting in early childhood, with a culture that represents opposing values. But all that culture does is awaken the child to the opposing values that were already sleeping within him, dormant, waiting to be awakened. This is the beginning of a lifelong encounter with the shadow, a movement toward completing the self.

The response to this problem, the development of this theme, comes later with the relocation of the forty dollars to the heart level and the robbery by the four hoodlums.

So, in order to be a little more specific, if I ask what part of me Williams Avenue is, I can say that it is the seed of my present ego structure, the beginnings of the value system that later became my dominant attitude and main viewpoint toward life. What is important to this dream is that this dominant attitude is one that squelches feeling, that is embarrassed by feeling and equates it with embarrassing emotionalism. It is a culture that mostly uses sentimentality as a substitute for real feeling.

The Japanese greengrocer

It is as though I have a separate little "civilization" living inside me that is like the old-fashioned Zen Buddhist culture of Japan. That part of me is focused on inner things, on the life of the soul, on contemplating the archetypes and the face of God, searching for inner harmony and consciousness. Even the external things that my inner Japanese culture is concerned with—the beauty of a kimono, the delicate formalities and courtesies in relationships, the graceful ways of showing respect and doing things—all are outward symbols of the harmony of the inner realm that one works for. They too refer me back to the divine world. They strike me as "outward signs of an inner grace."

The world I was born into on Williams Avenue taught me to be concerned mostly with outer things: Make a decent living, get the bills paid, get things done, get the house built and the garden planted, get along with the neighbors, and stay respectable in the eyes of the townsfolk. These qualities have their own value and relevance in life, but there is little room for the inner world in them.

It is the "Japanese" part of me that is interested in medieval, archetypal Christianity, in Zen, Hinduism, the great myths. It is the part of me that finds high, noble, and beautiful qualities in other cultures and religions.

But my main association is to the introverted, feeling quality in me. It corresponds later in the dream to the "heart" level. It is a capacity for

relationship that, at its best, does not get sentimental or “personal” in the sense of casual and artificial. It values loyalty and substance in relationships rather than effusive words or shows of emotion that don’t last.

The vacant lot

This seems to be a “place” inside my psyche that is surrounded by my ego structure or conscious mind (city streets) but is a little piece of unconscious wilderness, outside the control of my ego, where nature has its way and my shadow can hide out.

Can I find anything specific in my life that seems to correspond to this place? I know that there are funny “places” in my personality, lapses or lacunae, where I am suddenly uncivilized, without warning. It is as though I had suddenly reverted to the forest or jungle. They embarrass me, and I try to control them, but often I am unsuccessful.

I have been learning, however, that sometimes these are the areas in me where there is more spontaneity, life, feeling, and natural humanness than anywhere else. By trying to bring all these “vacant lots” under regimented control and make them respectable, I often squelch the best or most natural parts of myself.

I try to wade into these areas of my personality periodically—much as the fire department comes and cleans out the dead grass to reduce the fire hazard—to a little bit of consciousness and civilization there. But otherwise I decide to let the weeds and wildflowers grow unmolested.

I relate this to my feeling side. I get sudden enthusiasms for people. I suddenly like certain people and want to do things for them or spend time with them. I suddenly come off my formal, restrained, “civilized,” English gentleman persona and pour out my love or appreciation to someone in a spontaneous burst of enthusiasm. I often feel embarrassed by this and fear that I’ve embarrassed other people or that things are “out of control.” But this quality often reaches out of me and starts warm, good friendships. It has led me into deep, satisfying relationships with people in many different lands and cultures.

I am often in a quandary over this “vacant lot” inside me. I keep thinking I should clean it up, develop it, get it under control. But then I conclude that it is better to let nature run it. Sometimes, in the areas of love and feeling, wild grasses and wildflowers are better than formal gardens.

The wallet and the money

Based on my associations, I think the money refers to my inner resources,

my main energy and life force. The dream is focused on the question of where I focus my energy and my life. Money is something you invest, so where do I invest the main strength and resources, the main purpose and meaning of my life? In colloquial terms, where do I “bet my money”? Do I “put my money where my mouth is”?

The *fourness* of the money tells me this is no minor issue. This is my main life energy, the principle thrust or direction or commitment of my life. Where I put this dream money is symbolically the place where I invest my entire self, my life, my highest capacities. What values, what aspect of life am I committing all of that to?

The hip pocket

I am connecting this image to several overlapping collective attitude systems or beliefs inside me, a basic, unconscious, assumed way of looking at things. First, it is an attitude of wanting to be “hip” in the sense of being included in what certain groups of people are doing, wanting to be in or part of “the scene.” Also, I associate it with the “hippie” pattern of talking about “peace” and “love” when actually other motives are lurking behind the sentimental verbiage. All this adds up to a kind of collective *imitation* of deep feeling, but it is really a way of talking the language in order to fit in with people or with a fad. So I think the movement of my money away from that level and up to the heart level tells me that I have to move the money away from collective expressions of emotion or sentimentality and invest myself in real feeling relatedness to individuals and to the values that genuinely mean something to me.

Shirt pocket over left side of chest

In the first step, two ideas “clicked” strongly for me. One is the heart, and heart values. Second is the *anahata chakra* in kundalini yoga. Either way, I am connecting all this to the feeling function inside me and the feeling life within.

In step one I explained something of the feeling function and the difference between emotions and feelings. It took me a long time to come to the point where I associated this detail, the left shirt pocket, with the feeling side of myself. This is because I had never thought of myself as a *feeling* kind of person. I thought “feeling types” were the highly emotional ones. I thought that, since I’m not given to displays of emotion and can’t stand much sentimentality, I was not a feeling type, that I was dominated by thinking or intuition.

It was this association to the heart that made me look more closely and see that Jung did not mean “emotional” when he referred to a *feeling* type or a *feeling* function. This symbol forced me to look more closely at myself. I began to realize that the aspect of life that really motivates me, around which I involuntarily revolve my life, is the feeling side: the people who draw my love and whose magnificent quality I sense, and the values that capture my devotion and loyalty. It is these feeling relationships, of valuing and sensing the value in people, that energize my life and give it its center. That which moves me and inspires me most deeply in all of life is the beauty, nobility, and inner quality that I see in the human beings who come in contact with me.

Until I had this dream, I had always tried to repress this stream of energy in me, downplay it and keep it under wraps. In the family and the culture in which I grew up, feeling was not openly displayed. It was considered embarrassing, untrustworthy, impractical. If you were moved too deeply by a symphony, you would be considered a little strange. If you showed too much affection, it made others uncomfortable. Anyone who made decisions from the heart, rather than from cool practicality, was considered suspect as undependable. To feel, to love intensely, to be intoxicated with the beauty of a person, something in nature, or a value—all this would be inappropriate and out of place in respectable society.

In the aftermath of this dream, and my interaction with this symbol, I discovered my typology and the laws that go with it—I find that I am an introverted, feeling type, and the mainspring of my life is different than I had thought. So, I identified the part of myself that seems to correspond to this symbol—and I found a specific set of dynamics in my inner life that showed this part of me in action.

The movement of the money to this pocket seemed to me to represent a new investment of my energy, my capacities, my life itself, in the feeling function. I felt that it represented investing in a new center of consciousness, corresponding to the heart and the *anahata chakra*.

The hoodlums

During the first step I said that I associate the hoodlums with my inner *shadow*, my alter ego that is still unconscious and contains aspects of my personality that have yet to be integrated into my ego’s point of view. And I have to find specific aspects of my life in which I see this shadow at work.

If I look at my dream, again, as a series of developmental stages,

something comes clear. The hoodlum side seems to be a reappearance of the *other* complication in my Williams Avenue background: the Japanese greengrocer. The problem is the appearance of an *introverted, feeling quality* in my life, setting up a terrible conflict with my Anglo culture and training. It shows up first in the Japanese family. Then it reappears, and the conflict goes into a further development in the form of the shadow, the hoodlum quality.

The introverted, feeling quality is mine. But it couldn't find a respectable place to live in my ego world. Therefore it got repressed into a vacant lot, a little island of the unconscious inside my field of consciousness. My ego sees this part of me as a "hoodlum," but since the hoodlum appears as *four*, the dream is telling me that the hoodlum is a crucial part of me and that I need him in order to make myself whole.

Another reason that these shadow parts of ourselves show up as "hoodlums" is that they are forced into a "life of crime," so to speak, in order to survive in a world that is dominated by the ego and the ego's values. For example, if a feeling kind of man refuses to live his feeling side, his shadow will steal energy from him and invest it for him in his feeling side. Mostly this is done by compulsions: We fall in love against our will. Our hearts suddenly go off on crazy paths of their own, leaving our cool, collected minds aghast and struggling vainly to maintain order and dignity.

Our hoodlum feelings also steal energy by putting us into depressions and other moods. They make us physically ill. Depressions and moods and illness produce rather low-grade feeling lives, but the unconscious apparently feels that something is better than nothing. But our inner hoodlums also perform a noble role: Like Robin Hood, they steal from the rich and give to the poor. They steal from our wealthy ego empires and give to our undernourished feeling functions.

I could see this part of myself at work in my life in another way, also: The dream showed that the conflict between me and my hoodlum shadow went on and on until finally we became friends. And the crucial thing I had to do in order to stop the robbery, the loss of energy, and to become friends was to relocate my money at a different level—at the heart level. I could see that I had been in this conflict with my introverted, feeling side for many years, and it had been robbing me, through compulsions, through depressions, through psychosomatic illness. And finally, now, I could see that it was possible for me to put my money at the heart level, acknowledge my true feeling nature, and make friends with my hoodlums.

AN INTERPRETATION

As you may have noticed, I got somewhat carried away during the second step of my dream work, and I wound up doing a lot of the actual *interpretation*—developing an overview of the dream, seeing the dream in developmental stages, tying the dream together—that should actually be part of the *interpretation* stage. Sometimes it happens that way. You get halfway through the first step or the second step, and something lights up inside you, and you start tying the whole dream together. Fine. It doesn't really matter when the overall interpretation starts pouring out of you, as long as it gets done.

As a result, my interpretation can perhaps be rather short and to the point. I can go directly to the question of “What is the main, overall meaning that this dream has for me and my life?”

Primarily, the dream shows me that I am someone different than I thought I was, and that I have the *right*, as well as the duty, to live in accord with who I really am. In the aftermath of the dream I discover that I am an introverted, feeling type. The main focus of my life has to be my feeling values and my feeling relationships to the world around me, but especially to people.

Now, what does this mean to me, in practice, in the way I live my life? I can take courage and start devoting myself consciously, deliberately, to the feeling world. I can devote a large portion of my time and energy to cultivating my friendships, my relationships with people. I can devote time to the activities and subjects that have quality and depth and profound meaning for me. Most important, I can do this without feeling guilty, without feeling that I am giving in to some “hoodlum” side of myself, entertaining myself with the warm companionship of human beings when I ought to be doing something “useful.”

The essence of this dream is the relocation of energy: the relocation of energy from other levels to the “heart” level, the feeling level, of life. I don't have to spend my life trying to think, be logical and intellectual.

The dream shows this to me in a perspective that takes into account my entire life and a slow evolution that has gone on throughout my life up until the time of the dream. That evolution begins with childhood in the “Garden of Eden,” where I assume that there is only one viewpoint in life, that of my middle-class, Anglo Portland family and neighborhood. This becomes the dominant attitude system, the attitude system that runs my life for years to come, that defines my social personality and my concept of myself.

The “problem” aspect of the evolution—the conflict that must come into every life in order to engender growth—is symbolized to me as a child by the presence of the Japanese family, examples of an introverted, feeling culture that contrasts with my own and sets up involuntary resonances in the secret places in my soul. That urge, to be, in the midst of an unfeeling culture, a feeling human being, becomes the “hoodlum” in my unconscious, banished to the vacant lot, kept in hiding.

The *lysis* (resolution) of the dream, the resolution of the conflict, the healing of the split in the psyche, takes the form of this *relocation of energy* that is symbolized by the placing of my money at the level of the heart. This means that I can, and must, redefine my life around feeling values, around being a feeling person. And when my inner hoodlum finds that I have voluntarily relocated my energy, there is no longer anything to fight about.

EPILOGUE

In the aftermath of my work on the Dream of the Four Hoodlums I was at a loss as to what to do as a ritual for my fourth step. It took me a long time to fully understand the implications of the dream. I didn’t realize yet that I was going to eventually change the whole focus of my life and make feeling exchanges with people my top priority. But I knew I should do something, so I found a vacant lot, got out of my car, and walked around it a couple of times. That helped; it got me physically connected to the dream. Then I let it rest for a while.

By coincidence it happened that I traveled through Portland, Oregon, a few months later. I remembered my dream and decided that I could do a powerful ritual for reconnecting with my dream if I went back to my old neighborhood and actually walked around the places that had appeared in my dream. So it happened that I returned to the scene—of both my childhood and my fateful encounter with my feeling side.

I found Williams Avenue changed. I started at my old house and began walking over the route that I had taken in my dream. I passed the Japanese greengrocer’s. The building was still there, now a beer hall. I walked on and was half-startled to find the vacant lot was still there, after all these years, overgrown with bushes and shrubbery. Irrationally, in spite of myself, I started to get scared. I was no longer in the outside world; I was in my dream.

Suddenly, as I walked slowly past the vacant lot, a young man stepped out of the bushes and approached me. Well, the time had come, I thought: I was about to be robbed, just as in the dream. He was streetwise, just like the

hoodlums in the dream. He looked me over, and he sensed that I *wanted* something, that I was looking for something. Of course, he had no way of knowing that I was looking for a deeper understanding of my dream, that I was walking in my dream.

So he began to question me: Did I want marijuana? No. Then, what about cocaine? No. Did I want a woman? No. Heroin? No. When he had exhausted his list of possibilities, he finally asked, “Well, then, what *do* you want?”

It flashed through my mind that I could tell him that I wanted to talk with the hoodlums in my dream, that I wanted to walk by the Japanese greengrocer’s and the vacant lot until I connected with the parts of me that I had left there so many years before. I could have told him that I was walking in my dream and that he had walked into it and joined me. Perhaps he would have understood. But I didn’t. At that point the interaction between my dream world and the physical world had become too intense for me. I walked on, got into my car, and “fled the scene.”

By the time I put myself through this ritual I had touched my dream on as many levels as I could. It had become a vivid part of my life, an experience that I went back to in my mind repeatedly. Living with its symbols and the meanings that were slowly becoming more clear to me, I gradually altered my life to accord with the new conception of myself that the dream had planted in my mind.

What was that new conception? The dream forced me to realize that the most important thing in life to me is friendship and feeling-exchange with other people. I don’t need to have many acquaintances, but I require good friendships that involve a deep level of communication, whether it be an exchange of ideas or the simple joy of being together.

In response to the dream I made up my mind to go to India, to visit an ancient culture where people still related to each other through the archaic ties of clan and tribe, where warmth, feeling, and human exchange are valued above logic, order, and production. The series of visits I made to India and the Orient gave me a new reference point outside the mentality that I had been reared in. I gained a concrete sense of what it is to live among people who place love and feeling and human exchange above all other values; I felt at home.

Back in the United States, the effects of my dream on me continued. I began to pull out of the standard American way of life, with the goals, the excessive work schedule, the constant feeling of pressure and deadlines,

money to be made and people to be impressed. It was a slow process. But now, years later, I can say that the days of my life contrast greatly with those of the life I was leading when I dreamed of the four hoodlums. There is time for relaxation, for visiting friends, for planting in the yard, for listening to music, for Active Imagination. The succession of practical changes that made this possible began with this dream and the new attitudes that began to evolve inside me, the new conception of who I really am that began to develop in response to its symbols.

It is my hope that from the steps and the practical examples that we have explored together you will find it easier to get started on your own dream work and find the wisdom that awaits you in your own dreams. Remember that the unconscious continually expresses itself and voluntarily generates all the associations and references that you will need in order to understand your own dreams. All that is required, essentially, is your work: your willingness to begin and to follow the steps.

You may want to go beyond the bounds of this book and read more about the nature of dreams and of certain symbols or more about the ideas of Jung. You will find several books listed in the Bibliography that will help you. But basically, you will find, all that stands between you and understanding your dream is the act of writing down that first dream image, then writing down the first association that leaps into your mind.

From that first act—the crucial movement of the hand and the mind—begins all the magical and amazing unfolding of the inner mysteries that your unconscious stands ready to accomplish.